VENTURE

AI voice company Hyper raises $6.3M to help automate 911 calls

Dominic-Madori Davis — 9:00 AM PDT · July 21, 2025


IMAGE CREDITS: BEN SANDERS

"My whole life has been preparing me for this moment," Ben Sanders said when asked about why he launched his emergency response startup Hyper. The company announced Monday a $6.3 million seed round led by Eniac Ventures, as well as an official emergence from stealth.

As a child, he so wanted to become a police officer that he had his mother sew yellow stripes on his navy sweatpants. He wore that with an officer's rain hat for an entire year. As he grew up, he worked at the intersection of tech and government and once ran for federal office.

Around a year ago, he read a news article about how his hometown was looking to use AI to reduce the wait time for emergency services. Sanders, who once launched an AI voice for drive-through restaurants, suddenly had an idea. Though he didn't think AI was quite ready to help with 911 calls, he felt this was a space for innovation, especially after realizing that most calls made to the emergency line are not considered emergency calls at all.

Sanders teamed up with his friend Damian McCabe. The duo officially launched Hyper on Monday, offering an AI voice company that can handle some 911 calls. Sanders, who is CEO, said the product is to deal with the non-emergency calls that take time away from those critical calls that determine the "difference between life and death." McCabe is the company's CPO.

Most Popular

- Key sections of the US Constitution deleted from government's website
- Three weeks after acquiring Windsurf, Cognition offers staff the exit door
- Roku launches Howdy, a $2.99 ad-free streaming service
- Spotify raises subscription prices
- The uproar over Vogue's AI-generated ad isn't just about fashion

Right now, even if a person looked to call their local police department, they would most often find a 10-digit number that routes them to the same people who take 911 calls.

"Imagine getting stuck talking to someone for eight minutes about a neighbor's dog barking, only to answer the next call late, because of that noise complaint, and hear the trembling voice of a 5-year-old whose dad has just collapsed on the floor," Sanders said.

Hyper answers questions, texts links, forwards calls, and even takes non-emergency police reports. "Hyper always plays it safe, so if any calls fall outside the approved scope, or if one sounds slightly more emergency, we can automatically escalate those to a human expert just in case."

Sanders described the fundraising process as "frenetic, manic, and fast." It took him less than two months to raise the whole round, which was ultimately oversubscribed and included follow-on

- Your public ChatGPT queries are getting indexed by Google and other search engines
- The best dating apps aren't even dating apps

capital. Ripple Ventures, GreatPoint Ventures, VSC Ventures, Tusk Venture Partners, and K5 Global also participated in the round. Sanders said he met his connection at Eniac Ventures through a mutual acquaintance.

Hyper hopes to use the fresh capital to help scale across the country, integrate more into existing 911 systems, hire a head of engineering, and build its next product. There is some competition in this space, like Aurelian, which also sorts non-emergency calls. Sanders said what makes Hyper different from the rest is its focus on 911.

"We train our models on real 911 calls with local agencies," he said. "We support more languages. And we've already gone live with many centers, which is a big operational hurdle in government and public safety."

Sanders hopes that Hyper can take away at least some of the stress associated with being a 911 caller, in a way that perhaps even brings more people to the profession. Right now, he says, most call centers are understaffed and struggling to hire.

"It's such a tough job, I don't even know if I could do it," Sanders said. "But I know how to build technology that can help; to help call-takers and dispatchers who are the unsung heroes; to help reduce their burden by tackling the non-emergency calls and noise, and in doing so, ultimately help save lives."

Topics: fundraising Startups Venture venture

Dominic-Madori Davis
Senior Reporter, Venture

Dominic-Madori Davis is a senior venture capital and startup reporter at TechCrunch. She is based in New York...

View Bio

KEEP READING

IMAGE CREDITS: TECHCRUNCH / GETTY IMAGES

VENTURE

What founders should think about if looking to raise a Series C

Dominic-Madori Davis 6:00 AM PDT · August 2, 2025

Startup founders face a perplexing and even contradictory capital market in 2025, according to Sapphire Ventures partner Cathy Gao. “Capital isn’t scarce. But access to that capital is harder than ever,” she said.

Gao, who spoke at TechCrunch's All Stage conference in July, said it's possible for startup founders, especially those in the later Series C stage, to navigate this particular economic environment. And they need to start with a reality check.

To begin, she said, it's important to note that only one in five startups that raise a Series A ever make it to raise a Series C. And, in the past year, the bar for raising late-stage capital has only risen; investors are no longer just chasing momentum, as many were in the last few years — they are chasing *certainty*, Gao said.

"Investors are now asking: 'Is this company truly a winner in whatever market that they're serving?'" Gao said. "The question really isn't, 'Is this

remember that metrics do not always equal money. Sure, metrics are important, as are annual returns, growth, and retention, she said, but if investors are not sold on the idea that a company can truly become a leader in their respective space, then they are going to move on.

"Investors have to explain why a company will win in the future," she continued. For example, there are companies that don't have amazing metrics yet somehow raise a suitable Series C round. In one case, a startup nabbed more than a $2 billion valuation, she noted. "They were effectively able to communicate the story to investors why this company will be a leading company over time," Gao said of the company's successful raise.

Another Gao rule: Continuity is better than short-term virility.

In the age of AI, companies are growing faster than investors have ever seen before, she noted. "But oftentimes it's the case, what goes up also sharply comes down," Gao said. "So the question is, 'Is this growth sustainable?'"

In a Series C, investors are looking for "compounding loops," or seeing that the company gets stronger as it scales, she said.

"Does your product get better for every new customer you sign? Does your CAC [customer acquisition cost] decrease or increase for every new user you bring on board?" she asked.

If the answer is yes, then investors will "lean in," Gao said; if the answer is no, then investors are most likely to "lean out," even if a company's metrics look very strong.

Finally, she said, founders should treat fundraising like a go-to-market campaign and seek to develop relationships with VCs before pitching them for capital. Gao cited her firm as an example. Sapphire likes to invest in a company at the Series B level, but they usually have known the company for a year or longer.

"That means at the Series A, even though we're not actively leaning in to try and raise, we're trying to build a relationship with a company and with the founder," she said. "We're getting information and we're developing a longitudinal picture of how this company has progressed."

She said founders should start building a "lightweight investor CRM," or a database managing the relationships with investors.

Investors take notes while meeting with founders, and founders should do the same, she said. Founders should write down the names of partners, what they like to invest in, and what companies they've backed recently. Create a distribution list and send out periodic updates to the investors on it, she said. "This is an easy way to keep inventors in the loop."

Perhaps most importantly, however, Gao noted that a company looking to raise a Series C should not enter a fundraise until they've received a signal from multiple firms that they're interested in backing the round.

"The last thing you want to do is time the market incorrectly," she said. After all, timing is everything at the Series C level. "It's not about luck, pitching to a 50 and hoping that one says yes," she continued. "It's really about timing and planning ahead."

Topics: cathy gao Fundraising series C Startups Venture

Dominic-Madori Davis

Senior Reporter, Venture

Dominic-Madori Davis is a senior venture capital and startup reporter at TechCrunch. She is based in New York...

View Bio

KEEP READING

VENTURE

An investor makes a case for funding sex, drugs, and other socially taboo products

Dominic-Madori Davis — 6:00 AM PDT · June 9, 2025

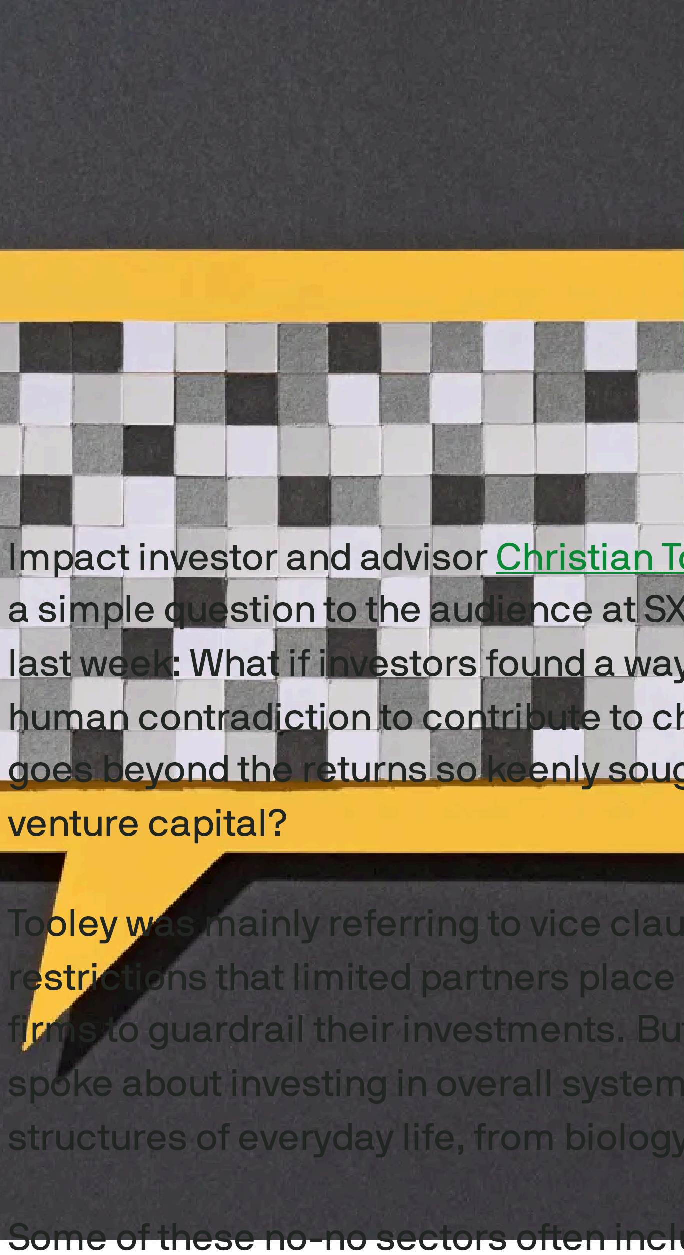


IMAGE CREDITS: MIRAGEC / GETTY IMAGES

Impact investor and advisor Christian Tooley posed a simple question to the audience at SXSW London last week: What if investors found a way to embrace human contradiction to contribute to change that goes beyond the returns so keenly sought for in venture capital?

Tooley was mainly referring to vice clauses, the restrictions that limited partners place on venture firms to guardrail their investments. But he also spoke about investing in overall systems, or the structures of everyday life, from biology to social.

Some of these no-no sectors often include products dealing with sex, substances like psychedelics, gambling, and tobacco, and such limitations are usually imposed by large institutional investors, who don't want to invest in products that are at best controversial and at worst potentially harmful.

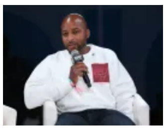
Tooley feels investors are missing out on innovation by keeping away from these so-called vices, especially where sex and substances are concerned. "Returns can be financial, cultural, and systemic," Tooley told the crowd. "Sex is high-volume, consumer-facing, with lower upfront capital needs. Substances have moderate-to-long ROI but higher payoffs."

He argued that such clauses are really more about bowing to the social stigma around these topics,

Latest in Venture

See More

FUNDRAISING

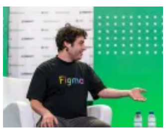


How to actually raise a seed round: Actionable advice from top investors at TechCrunch Disrupt 2025

TechCrunch Events

- 14 hours ago

STARTUPS



Figma's IPO success is 'a little bit of a meme stock,' says Sapphire Ventures' Jai Das

Rebecca Bellan,

Theresa Loconsolo

- 16 hours ago

even though some startups could be bringing about positive health and social benefits, in addition to being lucrative.

The sex tech market, for example, is expected to hit nearly $200 billion by 2032, he said. Over the years, the industry has received small but steady amounts of venture capital funding, a few hundred million at best. Specialized investors and firms, notably Vice Ventures, have sought to back more companies, but there hasn't been an onrush, especially from mainstream investors, to follow its lead.

Even OnlyFans, despite earning billions in revenue, struggled to find investors because of its association with pornographic content. "Entire industries are underfunded not because they lack merit, but because they challenge comfort," Tooley later told TechCrunch.

As an investor, Tooley has backed products such as Polari Labs, a tool that promises to improve anal sex, and linq, a company touting to provide a safer way to send nudes.

It's not surprising that large institutional investors steer away from such categories, as many of them are endowments and pension funds looking to avoid legal uncertainty and reputational harm. Some investors who passed on OnlyFans were worried about minors possibly being on the platform.

Regarding substances, cannabis is a good example, because it is only legal on a state-by-state basis. There are legal, regulatory, and tax uncertainties that could come with backing what is, in most cases, a criminalized product.

With less competition from institutional funds, Tooley says vice investing can be a particularly good opportunity for smaller LPs, family offices, and progressive funds. "If you only focus on the perceived controversy, you miss the innovation and often, the returns, too," he added.

Tooley said it is important to address the stigma around investing in areas that may be beneficial but are currently shunned. Tooley, for example, noted that it was considered controversial to talk openly about matters like menstruation.

Today, we have venture-backed companies like unicorn period tracker Flo, femble, and WomanLog.

Tooley imagines a world where more investors back taboo companies leading to better sexual health tools, psychedelic therapies with more cultural nuance, and biohacking relevant to queer and trans bodies. "We don't just need funders comfortable with risk," he said. "We need ones deeply uncomfortable with the status quo."

This piece was updated to clarify what the speaker talk was about.

Topics: fundraising SXSW Venture venture

Dominic-Madori Davis

Senior Reporter, Venture

Dominic-Madori Davis is a senior venture capital and startup reporter at TechCrunch. She is based in New York...

View Bio

Loading the next article